from the escalating violence that has characterised the city since the 1990s. The urban crisis authorised and demanded a new form of power in the city. Drawing on Giorgio Agamben's theories of the state of exception, Vainer claims that the preparations for these events have led to cities such as Rio becoming 'cities of exception'.

Cities of exception: the case of Rio de Janeiro

Inspired by the works of Foucault on biopolitics and governmentality, and also the reflections of Walter Benjamin, Hannah Arendt and Carl Smith, Giorgio Agamben has written about the state of exception. Agamben (1995) shows how the effects of the decisions made by the state (or whoever has the sovereign power) can lead to the exclusion of people from the political community and the protection provided by its laws and rights. In situations of crisis or war, exceptional actions are justified by the exceptional circumstances, leading to the acceptance of measures outside the legal framework. This permits the physical elimination of not only political opponents, but also of entire categories of citizens that are perceived as external and non-integral to society (Foucault 2003; Agamben 2005).

The notion of 'civilising' Rio has been a running theme in the city's history, with the upper classes attempting to control the activities, dress code and behaviours of the masses to serve their interests. Local elites have long fantasised about Rio being a First World city, and they have worked hard to maintain this illusion (Broudehoux 2001). As Brazil's capital of culture and tourism, Rio de Janeiro has been known as the *cidade maravilhosa* – the 'marvellous city', since the end of the 19th century. Parallel with the production of the image of the city as a tropical paradise, the urban informal settlements known as favelas sprang up as aberrations on the modern city. Throughout their history, the favelas have been rejected by the 'formal' city and have continually been threatened with destruction (Perlman 2010:26).

During the period of the military dictatorship (1964–85) the vast majority of the favelas of Rio de Janeiro were targets of public removal policies. The residents were moved to new housing estates in areas distant from the city centre – both to 're-civilise' these populations and to beautify the city. With the re-democratisation of Brazil in the 1980s, policies towards the favelas were revised. As they had proved incapable of solving the housing deficit in the city, the removal policies came to an end, and the public debate shifted to concentrating on the necessity of integrating the favelas in the city (Oliveira 2012:47). Programmes such as Favela-Bairro, launched by the municipality in 1993 to upgrade all of the